

ISMUN 4.0

BACKGROUND GUIDE



UNITED NATIONS OFFICE ON DRUGS

AND CRIME

Agenda: *Combating the Online Trafficking of Synthetic Opioids and
Disrupting
Anonymized Financial Networks on the Darknet.*

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LETTER FROM THE EB

“Loquere dum licet.”

Dear Delegates,

It is with immense pride and genuine pleasure that we welcome you to **ISMUN 4.0** and to the **United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime**. The mandate of UNODC extends far beyond responding to crime after it has occurred; it lies in understanding the networks, vulnerabilities, and systems that allow it to persist, and in bringing states together to address them. Your agenda reflects precisely that complexity.

A committee such as this demands a certain willingness to step forward. We expect each of you to make your presence felt without waiting for it to be handed to you. Do not wait for the room to acknowledge you; give it a reason to. Whether it is through an argument that changes the direction of debate, a question that forces a delegate to reconsider their position, or simply a perspective that nobody else has thought to raise, make what you say difficult to overlook. Speaking is, after all, where deliberation begins. There will be moments when you are unsure whether an argument is worth making, but if you spend the entire conference waiting for the perfect moment to speak, the conference will pass you by. We would rather see you engage, question, and contribute than allow hesitation to become the reason your ideas remain unheard. That same sense of initiative extends to participation. We will not come looking for you, nor should you expect to be carried through the conference by the momentum of others. Take the initiative to approach delegates, start conversations and pursue an argument beyond the few minutes in which it was first raised. **Be present in the process, not simply present for it.**

What we hope to see from you is genuine curiosity. Know your country's position well enough to defend it, but know the positions of others well enough to understand where those positions come from. A well-prepared delegate brings knowledge to the committee; a good delegate knows what to do with it. The difference lies in how you listen, how quickly you connect ideas, how thoughtfully you respond, and how naturally you can move between representing your country and engaging with the larger problem before you.

If we were to define what makes a delegate truly stand out, we would return to two things: **content and influence**. Content is the depth of your preparation, the understanding of your country's interests, its policies, its relationships, its limitations, and its position within the wider international landscape. Influence is what you are able to do with that understanding. It is measured by whether what you say makes someone think twice, strengthens an argument, or gives the committee a direction it did not have before. And beneath this lies something less measurable, but perhaps more important: **a genuine love for the game**. The willingness to stay engaged when debate becomes difficult, to enjoy the challenge of being questioned, and to keep looking for the next argument even after you think you have made your point. Marcus Aurelius wrote, "*Waste no more time arguing what a good man should be. Be one.*" We would borrow that sentiment for these two days. Do not spend them worrying about whether you are performing the role of a delegate correctly. Engage with it.

You have been given a committee, an agenda, a country to represent, and two days in which to make those things matter. What you choose to do with that opportunity will ultimately be **yours** to decide.

Until justice is served, and crime is not,

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MANDATE OF THE COMMITTEE

The **United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)** is the main global body tasked with fighting illegal drugs, international organized crime, and global terrorism. Established in 1997, the committee works directly with modern governments to build stronger courts, safer borders, and better police networks. UNODC helps Member States address illicit drugs, transnational organized crime, corruption and terrorism through research, technical assistance, capacity-building and international cooperation. The agenda crosses borders: production, precursor sourcing, online advertising, payment and shipping may all involve different jurisdictions. Unlike the UN Security Council, UNODC's decisions are recommendatory, not binding. This means the committee cannot force a country to change its laws or send in troops. To effectively address modern technological threats like darknet trafficking and anonymized cryptocurrency laundering, UNODC's operational mandate has expanded to encompass the following specialized mandates:

The Cybercrime Framework (UN Cybercrime Convention): UNODC serves as the administrative engine for the newly finalized UN Cybercrime Treaty. This mandate empowers the committee to standardize electronic evidence collection, simplify cross-border data requests, and help developing states build dedicated cyber-forensic units to dismantle hidden servers.

The Global Programme on Cybercrime (GPC): This specific operational branch provides long-term technical training to local law enforcement on cryptocurrency tracking, darknet infiltration tactics, and digital forensics. It ensures that police forces in vulnerable financial regions can trace transactions moving through advanced privacy networks.

Cooperation with the Financial Action Task Force (FATF): UNODC directly integrates its mandate with global anti-money laundering (AML) networks. The committee works to enforce standard financial tracking protocols, ensuring that virtual asset service providers (VASPs) and cryptocurrency exchanges strictly comply with global asset-seizure

COURSE OF COMMITTEE

PROCEEDINGS

Committee Dynamics: The committee will be conducted in a **fast-paced environment**, designed to test delegates beyond prepared speeches and conventional debate. Proceedings may be influenced by **unexpected developments and evolving circumstances connected to the agenda**.

Delegates should remain attentive and prepared to adapt their positions as new information emerges. Such developments may require delegates to reassess existing positions, engage in rapid negotiations, and formulate responses within limited preparation time. The committee will continue to incorporate formal debate, moderated caucuses, unmoderated caucuses, negotiations, and paperwork. However, delegates should be prepared for the direction of discussion to evolve as circumstances within the committee change. In the event of an unexpected development, delegates should focus on analysing before reacting, while considering:

- What has changed, and what is immediately at stake?
- Who is affected, and how does this affect my country's interests or existing position?
- What caused or enabled the development?
- What information is confirmed, and what remains uncertain?
- What are the possible unintended consequences of my proposed solution?
- How can this development strengthen my argument, expose inconsistencies, or create opportunities for negotiation?

Artificial Intelligence Policy: AI may be used responsibly to improve articulation, structure, grammar, or clarity. Ideas, arguments, analysis, and overall thought processes must originate from the delegate. Repetitive arguments across multiple speeches, particularly due to AI-generated content, should be avoided. The EB can distinguish between delegates demonstrating genuine effort and original thought and those who do not.

Committee email: unodcismun@gmail.com (All doubts and queries may be addressed here)

THE AGENDA IN CONTEXT

I. ORIGINS OF THE INTERNATIONAL DRUG-TRAFFICKING

PROBLEM: Synthetic opioids are drugs produced in laboratories which have an effect on the same receptors as morphine and heroin, fentanyl in particular becoming more common in the illegal drug markets. The international drug-control system was established as a response to the global opium trade, starting with early international initiatives such as the Shanghai Opium Commission of 1909 and the 1912 Hague Opium Convention. Current efforts place a greater emphasis on trafficking networks, precursor chemicals and illegal financial flows.

II. THE SHIFT FROM PLANT-BASED OPIOIDS TO SYNTHETIC

OPIOIDS: Opioids such as opium, morphine and heroin rely on the cultivation of the opium poppy, while synthetic opioids are substances produced in a laboratory, for example fentanyl and nitazenes. In order to produce them it is necessary to have accessible precursor chemicals, the appropriate equipment and the necessary expertise, which enables criminal organisations to set up or move clandestine laboratories in various areas rather than having to depend on particular agricultural regions. Because of their high potency it is possible to hide large amounts in small packages, and since there is increasing use of legitimately diverted precursor chemicals the chemical supply chains have become a major focus of enforcement actions. In 2022 the Commission on Narcotic Drugs placed norfentanyl, 4-AP and 1-boc-4-AP under international control. As a result synthetic opioids have made drug-trafficking networks more geographically flexible, decentralised and able to adapt to enforcement pressure

.III. THE EMERGENCE OF THE MODERN OPIOID CRISIS: The present opioid crisis evolved in a number of phases, these comprising the widespread misuse of prescribed opioids, an increase in heroin use, and from about 2013 the growing prevalence of illicitly manufactured fentanyl and other synthetic opioids. Illicit synthetic opioids can be very powerful and may be added to other drugs or to fake pharmaceutical products. As a result, drug traffickers are not always required to label a substance as fentanyl or some other synthetic opioid. The appearance of fentanyl analogues and nitazenes showed that new chemical variants could emerge more quickly than traditional control systems could react. The first nitazene analogue to be reported to UNODC's

Early Warning Advisory as part of this emerging trend was isotonitazene in 2019, after which many other analogues were reported

IV. THE DIGITALIZATION OF TRANSNATIONAL DRUG TRAFFICKING:

- **Emergence of the Darknet:** Traditional trafficking relied on producers, wholesalers, couriers, brokers and street-level distributors, requiring substantial physical interaction. The darknet, supported by infrastructure such as the Tor network, enabled suppliers and customers to connect remotely while making users and website operators more difficult to identify. Silk Road, operational from around 2011, demonstrated this model through online drug listings, Tor-based anonymity and Bitcoin payments, influencing later darknet markets.
- **Digitalisation of Drug Trafficking** Under the UNODC framework, digital drug trafficking involves the cyber-enabled advertising, sale and distribution laboratory-manufactured narcotics through the internet, encrypted communications and darknet marketplaces. Pseudo-anonymity, easy digital communication and relatively low operating costs make these platforms attractive to organised criminal groups. The borderless nature of cyberspace allows trafficking networks to operate across jurisdictions with greater flexibility and concealment.
- **Acceleration During COVID-19** Online trafficking predated COVID-19, but the pandemic accelerated reliance on online criminal business models. Increased internet connectivity and changing regulations, controls and enforcement responses enabled traffickers to adapt rapidly to changing circumstances.

VI. THE RISE OF ANONYMOUS FINANCIAL NETWORKS

The growth of online drug markets has led to new methods of transferring and hiding illegal funds. Since the beginning, Bitcoin had a strong link with the early darknet markets, offering a digital way of moving value across borders without the need for traditional face-to-face banking. Yet cryptocurrency is not naturally anonymous because blockchain transactions leave behind permanent records, and the problem for investigators is usually to connect a wallet or a transaction chain to a real individual or organisation. For this reason, criminal groups have in recent years made greater use of privacy coins, mixers, unhosted wallets and peer-to-peer exchanges in order to make it more difficult to trace the

funds, together with digital exchanges, intermediaries and shell companies which can hide the ownership and the movement of the illegal money. The investigation into DarkMarket in 2021 revealed more than 320,000 transactions and over €140 million in cryptocurrency transfers, showing how large the financial activity around major darknet markets is.

VII. HOW TRAFFICKING ROUTES EVOLVED: Traditional opioid trafficking had always been closely linked to the areas where the drugs were cultivated and to the established transport routes. Synthetic opioids, on the other hand, have reduced this dependence on specific geographical locations, trafficking networks now linking up precursor suppliers, chemical-manufacturing centres, clandestine laboratories, ports, and cross-border logistics. Online advertising and the use of cryptocurrency are now carried out alongside the physical movement of drugs through the postal and courier systems. A single drug-trafficking operation can thus extend over a number of jurisdictions and involve more than one authority, which is why international cooperation is essential

VIII. MAJOR HISTORICAL TURNING POINTS

Shanghai Opium Commission(1909): early major attempt at international cooperation against illicit opium trafficking.

Hague International Opium Convention(1912): established a foundation for modern international drug control.

Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs(1961): consolidated international controls over narcotic drugs.

Convention against Illicit Traffic(1988): strengthened the international response to trafficking, precursor chemicals, money laundering and international cooperation.

Silk Road(2011): demonstrated the use of darknet infrastructure and cryptocurrency for online drug trafficking.

AlphaBay and Hansa(2017): demonstrated the value of coordinated international cyber-investigation.

CURRENT GLOBAL DYNAMICS

I. DARKNET MARKETS: RESILIENCE DESPITE REPEATED

TAKEDOWNS: Even though international enforcement has been ongoing, darknet markets have still managed to remain highly adaptive. The total amount of cryptocurrencies transferred through darknet markets reached almost \$2.6 billion in 2025, showing that crypto-powered drug markets continue to exist even after numerous interventions have taken place. Instead of relying on a single permanent marketplace, vendors and buyers now tend to move between different platforms after sites are closed, seized or disrupted.

The fact that **Abacus Market disappeared in July 2025** and was then succeeded by TorZon shows that users and vendors are able to quickly move from one market to another rather than exiting the broader ecosystem. This situation therefore leads to a major problem when it comes to enforcement: removing a single platform does not necessarily mean that the wider trafficking and financial infrastructure which supports it is destroyed.

II. 2025: MAJOR INTERNATIONAL DARKNET ENFORCEMENT OPERATIONS

- **Operation RapTor:** Operation RapTor, which was announced in May 2025, led to 270 arrests in ten countries, focusing on darknet vendors and buyers who were involved in the trading of drugs, weapons and other illegal goods. The authorities also seized more than \$200 million in cash and digital assets, as well as large amounts of drugs, including those related to fentanyl.
- The investigators identified the people who carried on operating on the various networks by using the intelligence gathered from previous takedowns of online marketplaces, such as Nemesis, Tor2Door, Bohemia and Kingdom Markets.
- **III. THE ARCHETYP MARKET TAKEDOWN:** In **June 2025**, European authorities shut down Archetyp Market, one of the longest-running of the major darknet drug markets. The market had been going for more than five years, had gathered over 600,000 users, and had carried out at least 250 million euros in transactions. Archetyp was especially important since it allowed the sale of fentanyl and other highly potent synthetic opioids. This operation shows both the extent of darknet

markets and how difficult it is to get rid of them altogether, especially when displaced users and vendors can move onto other platforms.

IV. SYNTHETIC OPIOIDS ARE DIVERSIFYING BEYOND FENTANYL

The threat from synthetic opioids is not any longer confined to fentanyl and its analogues since nitazenes have become a major new factor. In February 2025 the UNODC had reported that **26 different nitazenes** had been identified in 30 countries in Europe, North America, Oceania, South America and Southeast Asia. By 2024 more new nitazenes than new fentanyl analogues were being sent to the UNODC and nitazenes made up almost half of the opioid-related new psychoactive substances reported. The fact that there is such a diversification presents a regulatory problem since traffickers can shift to new chemical variants before governments and the international control systems have had the opportunity to fully evaluate or bring them under control

V. SYNTHETIC OPIOIDS ARE APPEARING IN NEW FORMS: Synthetic opioids are now being found in forms and as mixtures that were not expected, making it harder to identify and enforce regulations. New substances can appear before governments have set up the necessary testing methods, reference standards or national controls. As a result, the issue has moved from merely seizing fentanyl to continuously identifying and bringing under control the rapidly changing varieties of synthetic opioids.

VI. TRAFFICKING ROUTES ARE BECOMING MORE CHEMICAL- AND SUPPLY-CHAIN-BASED: The logic of traditional drug trafficking has been changed by synthetic drugs. Unlike with heroin or cocaine, synthetic opioids do not need a large area for agricultural cultivation and can therefore be produced near the destination markets, with the trafficking networks handling the transport of the precursor chemicals, the equipment, the finished drugs and the financial payments. Present-day investigations show that China is a major source of illegal fentanyl precursor chemicals and pill-pressing equipment and that India has also become an important source of precursor chemicals.

Instead of just importing finished fentanyl, Mexican trafficking organisations have increasingly obtained the precursor chemicals and have thus set up supply chains that link together the suppliers of the chemicals, the intermediaries, the production networks and the destination markets. The trafficking chain may

therefore involve a number of jurisdictions carrying out different functions, rather than following a single traditional route from producer to consumer.

VII. THE MEKONG REGION AND SOUTHEAST ASIA ARE BECOMING INCREASINGLY RELEVANT TO THE PRECURSOR-SUPPLY:

Inquiries have found networks that involve suppliers, brokers, manufacturers, and financial intermediaries in a number of Asian countries. Southeast Asia is therefore relevant not just as a destination or transit area but also as part of the precursor, production and financial infrastructure associated with the trafficking of synthetic drugs.

VIII. THE CENTRAL CURRENT DYNAMIC:

The present threat is the result of the quick adaptation on the part of both synthetic-opioid trafficking and darknet markets. While fentanyl is no longer the only synthetic opioid in circulation, nitazenes are now appearing in a number of areas, and the precursor chemicals together with the production networks are being moved via ever more complicated international supply chains. On the same time, darknet sellers and buyers keep switching from one platform to another as a result of law enforcement actions, as was the case following the closure of the Archetyp and Abacus Market and the subsequent emergence of new markets. Law enforcement agencies are now focusing more on the links between these activities. For example, operations like RapTor have brought together darknet intelligence, blockchain tracing, the seizure of cryptocurrencies, and information gathered from earlier investigations in order to spot individuals who kept on operating across various platforms.

The financial structure can connect precursor suppliers, manufacturers, online vendors, cryptocurrency intermediaries and laundering networks, the different stages of which take place in several countries.

The **main problem** facing the committee is to break down a trafficking system which is capable of quickly adapting its drugs, its supply routes, its online platforms and its methods of financing. Since it is a question of achieving long-term disruption, it is necessary to trace the connections between new synthetic opioids, the supply chains of the precursors, the darknet markets and the illicit financial networks..

INTERNATIONAL RESPONSE AND EXISTING LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

The global community currently relies on three major United Nations treaties to fight illegal drugs. These treaties create the legal baseline for international police cooperation:

1961 Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs	1971 Convention on Psychotropic Substances	1988 Convention Against Illicit Trafficking
Targeted organic plant drugs Banned non-medical possession and sales Kept use for medicine	Expanded rules to meet the rise of early synthetic laboratory chemicals Created early safety control schedules	Targeted financial tracking and chemical ingredients Created basic laws to fight money laundering and supply diversion in factories

1)INTERPOL’s Cybercrime Directorate: Functions as a global intelligence hub, facilitating cross-border data sharing, hidden server mapping, and synchronized multi-nation raids.

2)Joint Action Task Forces (J-TACs): Multi-agency coalitions (such as the units behind *Operation SpecTor*) unite cyber-divisions from Europol and the US FBI to infiltrate marketplace source codes, unmask database administrators, and seize vendor mailing lists.

3)The EU’s MiCA Regulation: The Markets in Crypto-Assets (MiCA) framework enforces full transparency by requiring crypto platforms operating in Europe to hold official licenses and apply stringent anti-money laundering (AML) controls.

4)Blockchain Analytics Partnerships: Law enforcement agencies partner with private data firms (such as *Chainalysis*) to utilize machine-learning algorithms that map out complex coin-mixing patterns and de-anonymize transactions.

5)The INCB ION Project: Operated by the **International Narcotics Control Board**, the *IONICS* secure communication platform serves as a real-time global alert system for customs offices to log and share intelligence on the suspicious movement of non-scheduled chemical precursors.

6)The Universal Postal Union (UPU) Standards: Partnering with the UNODC, the UPU enforces **Electronic Advance Data (EAD)** protocols. International packages containing goods are blocked at borders unless they carry digital tags specifying the sender, recipient, and contents, allowing customs centers to use automated data screening to flag high-risk parcels.

CASE STUDIES

CASE STUDY 1: IMPLEMENTATION OF THE FATF TRAVEL RULE FOR VIRTUAL ASSETS: The FATF Travel Rule (Recommendation 15) requires VASPs to collect and transmit relevant information on the originator and beneficiary of virtual-asset transfers. As per its 2025 assessment, FATF reported that 99 jurisdictions had passed or were in the process of passing legislation implementing the Travel Rule, covering about 98 per cent of the global virtual-asset market. According to the FATF, there continues to be gaps in the implementation of the rule, which is relevant to tracing cryptocurrency.

CASE STUDY 2- OPERATION DESTABILISE — DISMANTLING THE FINANCIAL NETWORK: Operation Destabilise was led by the UK National Crime Agency with the support of international partners. The operation set about exposing not one but two major Russian-speaking money-laundering networks in 2024. As many as 84 people were arrested. What's interesting to note is that these networks facilitate the laundering of several billions of dollars each year. Another highlight of this operation was how these networks were found to be potentially linked to drug trafficking and other organized crime. Through the operation, authorities showcased how the financial infrastructure of cryptocurrency allows connecting drug proceeds with wider money laundering services, the underlying intelligence for the investigators to target this network.

QARMA

QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER:

1. *How can Member States disrupt online synthetic-opioid trafficking while preventing the rapid migration of vendors and buyers between darknet platforms?*
2. *How can international drug-control mechanisms respond more rapidly to emerging synthetic opioids, including nitazenes and new analogues?*
3. *How can States strengthen controls on precursor chemicals and manufacturing equipment without disrupting legitimate trade?*
4. *What mechanisms can identify, trace and dismantle cryptocurrency networks financing synthetic-opioid trafficking while protecting legitimate virtual-asset activity?*
5. *How can law-enforcement agencies, financial institutions, cryptocurrency exchanges and blockchain-analytics organisations strengthen cooperation against illicit financial networks?*
6. *How can enforcement prevent darknet-market takedowns from displacing trafficking to new platforms, routes or financial channels?*
7. *How can Member States securely share digital evidence and financial intelligence across borders while respecting national legal requirements?*
8. *If Member States establish a new international commission or regulatory mechanism, what should its mandate, authority, membership, funding and financial oversight entail?*
9. *How can international authorities identify emerging trafficking routes, production centres and financial channels before they become firmly established?*
10. *What measurable mechanisms should assess whether international action is reducing synthetic-opioid trafficking and disrupting its associated financial networks?*

RESEARCH REPOSITORY

This research repository provides delegates with reliable sources to deepen their understanding of the agenda and support evidence-based preparation. Delegates are encouraged to consult these resources when researching national positions, existing frameworks, recent developments and potential solutions.

1. <https://www.unodc.org/lss/page/about>
2. <https://globalinitiative.net/analysis/digital-drug-revolution-online-markets-global-illicit-trade-ocindex/>
3. <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/en/publications/Methodsandtrends/Money-laundering-fentanyl-synthetic-opioids.html>
4. <https://www.chainalysis.com/glossary/darknet-markets/>
5. <https://www.un.org/en/delegate/un-responds-global-opioid-crisis>
6. <https://youtu.be/Pzh2fNpq77I?si=2DyKCE4i8ewmRKLW>
7. <https://youtu.be/ngT2Aq1VBFc?si=9WiLiLdW-EGlTEJ8>
8. <https://www.chainalysis.com/blog/crypto-drug-sales-darknet-markets-2026/>

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